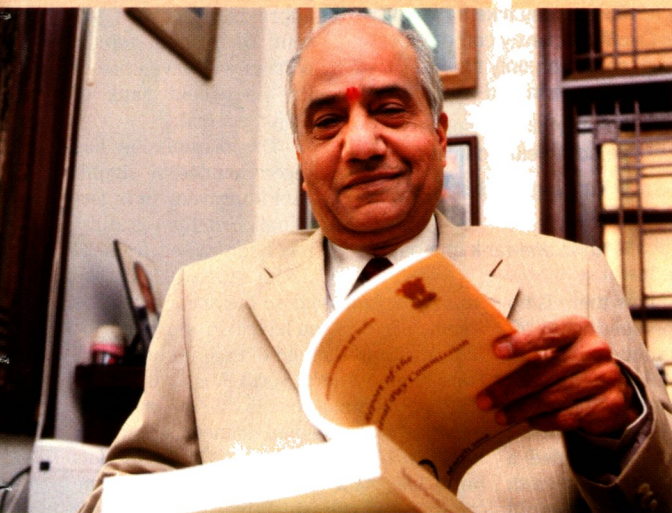


the pitfalls they leave

PROPOSAL: Enhanced pay scales for nurses, teachers, constabulary, postmen and forest guards.

PURPOSE: This is necessary to attract and retain talent. Will also help in creating resource capacity.

PITFALL: Absenteeism is worst among workers in healthcare and education sectors. No steps taken to address this problem.



BHASKAR PAUL

GIVE AND NO TAKE: Justice Srikrishna

will earn Rs 6,660 per month or Rs 79,920 a year (plus allowances would be Rs 7,681). In a country with 310 million people living below a dollar a day, over 20 million employees working at the Centre, in the states and with the public sector units will share the Rs 12,561 crore booty. The babu at the lowest rung of the government will earn twice India's per capita income of \$1,000. A secretary to the government who earned Rs 26,000 till last month will earn Rs 80,000 per month (besides perks) or \$24,000 per year. With allowances, the figure would touch Rs 96,000. This does not account for the assurance of tenure, the plethora of allowances, transport facilities and the large bungalows in prime localities. A secretary is entitled to a bungalow of between 350 sq m and 522 sq m for a payment of just Rs 2,290. Imagine paying a fee of Rs 2,290 (plus besides foregoing HRA of Rs 8,600) to live in Lutyen's

INTERVIEW | JUSTICE B.N. SRIKRISHNA

“Our brief was reconstructing pay, not all-round reforms”

The Sixth Pay Commission is perhaps the first commission to deliver its recommendations on time, with a third of the sanctioned staff, two-thirds of the sanctioned budget and no foreign junkets. Chairman Justice B.N. Srikrishna answers some of the concerns.

Q. What is the basic thrust of the Sixth Pay Commission report?

A. The pay of the government employees was last revised in 1996 and had remained static thereafter except for the merger of DA into basic in 2004. Since the state of the economy has drastically improved, government servants had a legitimate expectation. At the same time, one cannot forget that the government earns no profits and is intended to carry out developmental activities. The commission has tried to hold the balance between public interest and private interest of the government servants by treading the middle path.

Q. There is a perception that certain grades at the lower level have got less than those at the top.

A. This is not wholly true. The pay rise is about 85 per cent at the lowest level and works out to about 122 per cent at the secretary level and about 114 per cent at the cabinet secretary level. The disparity at the higher levels between public and private salaries was much larger.

Q. There are a plethora of allowances, from bad weather to machine allowance.

A. The report is clear about the allowances that are to be discontinued but did not think it necessary

to discontinue them as they did not have much fiscal impact.

Q. Delivery of services is pathetic in government. What is the efficiency quotient of this package?

A. The efficiency in any service depends on the carrot and the stick. Our job was concerned with the former and not the latter. We have tried to incentivise the government servants by differential increments, performance-related pay, and abolition of overtime and irrationally structured productivity-linked bonus.

Q. There is duplication of functions at the Centre and the states. Wouldn't this have been a good time to cut flab?

A. Yes, agreed, but that is really the job of the Administrative Reforms Commission. Our brief was limited to restructuring of pay and did not extend to all-round administrative reforms, although, ideally, both should have gone hand-in-hand.

Q. Will all your recommendations including the performance related incentive system be accepted?

A. We have dovetailed the recommendations in such a manner that any tinkering with it would render it irrational and absurd. We have also specifically warned the Government about this in the report. Hopefully, the Government will take note of the advice.